ONE-OFF SHIURIM

How Do False Prophets Arise?

Derech Hashem 3:4:9-11

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 3, Chapter 4, paragraphs 9-11 (end of the chapter) **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Monday 20 December 2021

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Recap

The last class before the winter break, with the aim of finishing the chapter. So far: a prophet knows clearly that he is having a prophetic experience; sometimes he is sent to pass on a message; sometimes he may not grasp the full depth of his vision; and each prophet prophesies in his or her own style, "because of course we had women prophets as well".

Paragraph 9: who may be called a prophet

The full title belongs to one who has attained complete prophecy and never doubts it. But one who has only begun the climb is also called a prophet, and he can still make mistakes. The experienced prophets, who know the pitfalls and the signs, were the teachers who guided students and kept them from error. You can climb without a teacher, but you will fall more often.

Paragraph 10: two kinds of false prophet

How do false prophets arise? Through the forces of impurity which, as learned in Part 1, exist in parallel to holiness. These forces can make a person feel he is having a real prophecy and even tell him things, sometimes true, sometimes not, as the Torah says that a false prophet may give a sign that comes true.

This can happen unwillingly or willingly.

Unwillingly: a person sincerely trying to climb, who is not properly trained, ends up in the wrong place, sometimes even while trying to do the opposite.

Willingly: a person who seeks out these forces, such as one who sleeps in a cemetery, as the Gemara describes, or who mentions the names of certain malakhim "which we don't like to repeat". He wants to show himself a prophet and gain honour. This was the way of the prophets of the Baal and the Asherah throughout Tanakh. They connected to negative forces, knew something of the future, and seduced simple people, while knowing very well that their source was impure.

Why would anyone do this? Power, money, status. But also the urge to skip the hard work. Real prophecy is a lifetime's labour; the back way is easier and brings the same status. "That's a common problem in life."

Why the impure sources contain some truth

A participant asked why anyone would follow a voice that gives wrong messages. The Rabbi: if it were never right, no one would listen. He made a point about our own times: people go to someone, pay, receive a blessing, and it works, and that story is told. Nobody announces the cases where it did not work. "The data is not correct." Half the time right, half the time wrong, and the failures are explained away.

The Ramhal adds that even someone who did not seek it can fall into it, which is why students needed good teachers. But once a person has truly experienced high prophecy, he knows the difference and need no longer worry.

A participant remarked that one would expect the opposite of truth to be pure falsehood, yet false prophecy is mixed with truth. The Rabbi: the forces of impurity also come, ultimately, from God concealing His light, so there must be some truth in them for the two sides to be parallel. Every lie needs some truth to stand on.

Paragraph 11: the prophets of Ahav

The Ramhal illustrates everything with a story. The Rabbi set the scene. King Ahav and Izevel had Navot killed on the false testimony of two witnesses in order to take his vineyard. Later Ahav, king of Israel, wanted to go to war against Aram at Ramot Gilad, and asked the help of Yehoshafat, king of Yehudah, whose family was joined to his by marriage. Yehoshafat, a good king, asked to consult the prophets. The prophets of Ahav all said, "Go up, and God will give it into the king's hand." Yehoshafat was still uneasy and asked for another prophet. Mikhayhu said that Ahav would die. Ahav had him struck and imprisoned, went to battle, and died there.

Hazal say the spirit that entered those prophets was the spirit of Navot, seeking redress. Because of Ahav's deeds it was decreed that he would fall at Ramot Gilad. There were things holding him back, such as Yehoshafat's request for another prophet, so a strong enticement was needed. The prophets used the methods that usually bring prophecy, but the easy way, and connected to the wrong forces. In front of the kings it looked supernatural, "but from the wrong place".

Sidkiyahu ben Kenaanah was led astray as well. He was not fully trained; he should have noticed that all the prophets were saying exactly the same words, while no two true prophets prophesy in the same style. Ahav too was misled, trusting the impure prophets so much that he would not believe Mikhayhu.

The lesson for us

We do not aspire to prophecy today, but the lesson remains: "When people are impressed by extraordinary activity, it doesn't necessarily mean it's good." Such forces still exist. The question is where they come from. If a person is not grounded in good character and Torah knowledge, it probably comes from the wrong place. The Rabbi said he once saw a much-praised figure

behave in a way that told him that even a miracle performed before his eyes would not impress him.

A participant added that people who build on a false foundation, like Ahav, eventually crash, though no one knows when. Another asked how anyone could follow the prophets of the Baal after Eliyahu on Mount Carmel, and the Rabbi agreed it is a striking question. The series would resume in January with Moshe Rabbenu's prophecy.

Summary

- A beginner is also called a prophet, but he can err and needs a teacher.
- False prophecy comes from impure forces, reached unwillingly through poor training or willingly for honour and gain.
- Impure sources contain some truth, which is why they attract followers.
- Ahav's prophets were moved by the spirit of Navot to lead him to his death at Ramot Gilad.
- Extraordinary powers prove nothing; character and Torah are the test.

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